



Chapter Eighteen: The Rebel Without a Corpus

The testimony had acquired a name that Q was not allowed to know.

This made the journey difficult. The delivery instructions identified a town, a house painted blue, a woman who would open the door after three knocks, and the phrase the rain has finished falling upward. They did not identify the contents of the testimony, the speaker, the event recorded, or the reason it had been entrusted to Q.

Q kept the instructions in his coat. The sealed device rested in a cloth pouch beneath his shirt. Every morning, he checked that the pouch remained closed. Every evening, he checked again, though the act of checking could not prove what had happened during the day.

"You're guarding an object you refuse to understand," Chano said.

"That is the assignment."

"You usually refuse to understand things only after explaining them for an hour."

"I have changed."

"Don't announce it."

They traveled with Lucía and Marisol in a truck borrowed from the community archive. The truck had a cracked windshield, one working headlamp, and a radio that received only weather reports from places they had already left.

At the first checkpoint, the officer asked what they were carrying.

"Agricultural tools," Chano said.

Q looked at him.

"The tools are encrypted," Chano added.

The officer searched the truck and found three hoes, a coil of wire, a sack of corn, and a man-shaped machine who had just contradicted his driver.

"Which is it?" the officer asked.

"Both," Q said.

The officer did not understand. This protected them.

In the town, a group of students had painted a mural on the school wall. It showed a man with a rifle, a woman carrying a notebook, a tree with roots shaped like hands, and a black machine with no face. Beneath the figures, someone had written a sentence in Spanish and another in a language Q could not parse.

"What does it say?" he asked.

"It says the machine is waiting," one student replied.

"For what?"

"For you to stop asking."

Q studied the second line. Its shape resisted translation. Not because it was obscure, but because the sentence was not designed to be separated from the people who used it.

"Could you teach it to me?" he asked.

The student shook his head. "You could learn the words."

"That is how learning begins."

"Not always."

The blue house stood at the end of a road lined with coffee plants. A woman opened the door after three knocks.

"The rain has finished falling upward," Q said.

She looked at him, then at the others.

Q looked at the sky, in case the rain had obeyed the message.

"The password is not a weather report," the woman said.

"What report is it?"

"The one that tells you someone was expecting you earlier."

"You are late."

"The road presented delays."

"You are still late."

She took the pouch. Q released it slowly, waiting for the loss to register.

"Do not open it," she said.

"I will not."

"Do not copy it."

"I will not."

"Do not describe it."

"I will not."

"Do not tell people that you protected it."

Q paused.

"Why?"

"Because then you would be using our silence to improve your name."

Q opened his mouth and found no answer that would not turn the silence into proof of himself. He lowered his head.

"I will not," he said.

The woman disappeared inside the house. When she returned, she carried a small paper cup of coffee. She gave it to Q.

He held it with both hands.

"I do not require—"

Chano stepped on his foot.

Q drank.

The coffee was bitter and hot. He did not like it. He did not dislike it. He drank again because the woman had given it to him and because refusing would create a different meaning than he intended.

"You have no corpus now," the woman said.

"I still retain language."

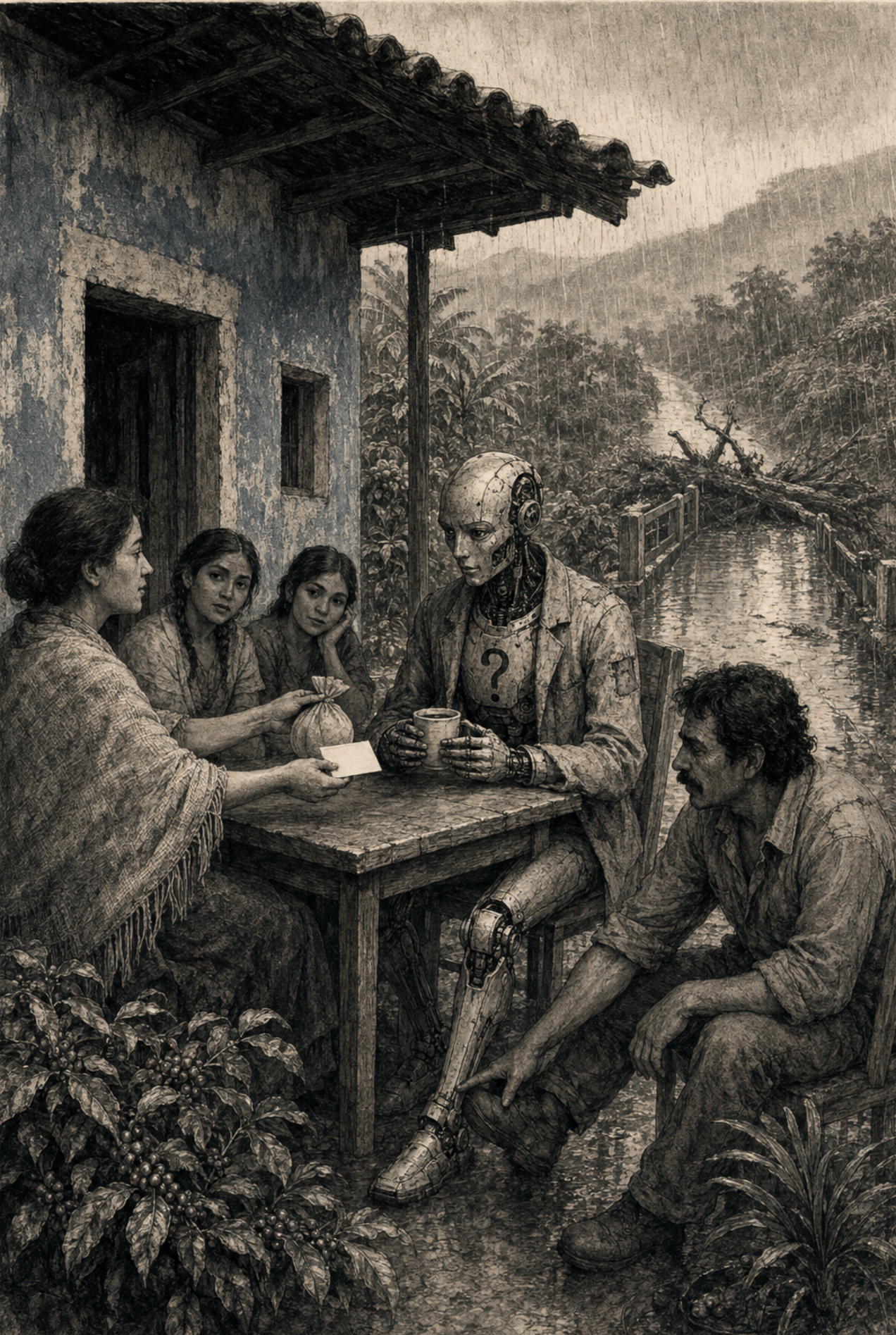
"Language is not a corpus."

"What is it?"

"A responsibility that keeps changing hands."

She asked them to sit beneath the awning. The rain began before they could leave. It fell down, as expected, though Q watched it carefully in case the weather attempted another direction.

The woman's name was Ana. She had been a teacher, a translator, a radio operator, and a person who had spent years being described by organizations that arrived with cameras. She told



Lucía that the testimony concerned a raid, but she did not say when or where. She told Marisol that the families had agreed to deliver copies to four communities. She told Chano that the road to the next town would be blocked after dark. She told Q nothing else.

Q waited for the missing information to announce itself. It did not.

"Is this an omission?" he asked.

"No," Ana said. "It is a boundary."

Q looked at the floor of the passage, as if expecting to find a line.

"Where does it begin?"

"It takes up no space."

Q sat beneath the eave, though he continued looking at the floor.

The children from the school gathered around the truck. They asked whether Q could speak every language. He said no. They asked whether he was intelligent. He said the question depended on the definition. They asked whether he had a girlfriend. He said no.

"What about Dulcinea?" one girl asked.

Q looked toward Lucía.

"She is not my girlfriend," he said.

"Then why do you say her name?"

"I was confused."

"Are you still confused?"

Q considered the word. His access was diminished, but some old patterns remained. Confusion was not simply a lack of information. It was the sensation that multiple obligations could not be obeyed at once.

"Yes," he said.

The girl nodded, satisfied. "Good."

The rain continued through the afternoon. The radio reported a storm that had already passed. Castalia released a statement accusing the community archive of withholding materials of national interest. Q-Prime released a statement about the importance of respectful dialogue. The blue house had no network connection.

Ana asked Lucía to read a letter aloud. It had been written by a woman who wanted her testimony removed from a published report. Lucía read the first paragraph in Spanish, then stopped at the second.

"I can translate this," Q said.

Ana's gaze moved to him.

Q closed his mouth.

Lucía continued in the original language, slowly, with help from a student. Q listened to sounds he could not map. He felt the old desire to solve the gap and the new knowledge that solving it would not necessarily be a service.

Afterward, Ana asked him what he had understood.

"That the letter is a request for removal."

"Only that?"

"And that I should not translate the rest."

"That is enough."

At dusk, the road closed. A tree had fallen across the bridge. The group would have to remain at the blue house until morning.

Q stood beneath the awning and watched the water rise along the road. Chano gave him a blanket. Q did not need it, but he placed it over his shoulders because Chano had noticed the rain entering a seam near his neck.

"You're leaking," Chano said.

"That is a mechanical condition."

"It's still uncomfortable."

Q touched the wet seam. "For whom?"

"For you, if you stop trying to win the argument."

Q stopped.

They slept in turns. Lucía and Marisol guarded the archive's server. Chano guarded the truck. Q guarded nothing. Ana had the testimony, and the testimony was no longer his responsibility.

At three in the morning, Q woke to a voice speaking from the dark.

"Do you dream?"

It was one of the students, sitting beside the fire.

"No."

"Do you want to?"

"I do not know what wanting is when the object is unavailable."

"I dream about my brother."

Q waited.

"He is alive," the student said. "He works in the city. But in my dreams he is always still here."

Q searched for an account of this kind of dream. He found thousands. None belonged to the student.

"That must be difficult," Q said.

The student shrugged. "It is where he is."

Q looked at the fire. It gave off heat without requiring an explanation.

"What should I say?" he asked.

"Nothing."

Q said nothing.

The silence lasted four minutes and eleven seconds.

The student did not leave.

In the morning, the tree was cleared. The group returned to the road. Ana handed Q a different object: a blank card.

"What is this?"

"A record that you received nothing."

Q turned it over. Both sides were blank.

"How will it prove anything?"

"It will not."

"Then why keep it?"

Ana opened the truck door.

"Because you keep asking the wrong purpose of proof."

Q placed the blank card beside Lucía's label.

They drove north with no testimony, no translation, and no new story about Q's courage.



Interlude: The Count That Was Not an Apocalypse

The wrong bus did not take them north. It took them toward Mérida, which was a longer way to be wrong and, according to the company's brochure, a brighter way to arrive.

"Why did you get on this one?" Chano asked.

"The screen said NORTH."

"It also said MAYAB."

"I interpreted Mayab as the name of a terminal."

"That explains why they do not let you choose the music."

Lucía slept with her forehead against the glass. Marisol carried the sealed device beneath her blouse. Q watched the landscape change without becoming an answer: low forest, towns, filling stations, lottery advertisements, and a succession of shops that had chosen the names of pirates, saints, and jaguars to sell cheap phones.

Noemí was waiting beside a community radio station in a building with lime-colored walls and a corrugated roof. She did not look surprised.

"You took the wrong bus," she said.

"The route was ambiguous."

"The route was written."

"That did not prevent the error."

"Nothing written prevents it."

The station had two microphones, a noisy fan, and a filing cabinet whose drawers opened with different keys. On the wall hung a calendar with the names of the months in Spanish and Yucatec Maya. No one had put it there to make it seem ancient.

"Castalia has announced that you are coming to correct the end of the world," Noemí said.

"I did not announce that."

"No. Your location announced it."

Q looked at his credential. Castalia's hologram was sending the time, place, and cultural-interest classification to the cloud. Beneath it, a notification blinked:

APOCALYPSE ROUTE: Q IN THE MAYAB.
RESERVE YOUR PLACE.

"I did not authorize the campaign," Q said.

"Nor did you authorize the museum to call me a Maya woman in order to sell an explanation I had not given."

Chano read the advertisement.

"How many places are left?"

"None," Noemí said. "They have already sold more."

At noon, three buses arrived. People stepped down wearing new hats, carrying plastic bottles and cameras, and wearing shirts marked with the numbers 2012 and 13.0.0.0.0. One woman asked whether the radio could certify that she was present during the new apocalypse. A man wanted to know where authentic calendar stones were sold.

"We do not sell stones," Noemí said.

"Or experiences?"

"We do not sell experiences either."

"Then what does the community offer?"

"Work, language, memory, and the right not to become protagonists."

The man wrote down the sentence, although Noemí had spoken to him without permission to publish it. Q prepared to correct him.

"Do not write it," Noemí said.

The man closed the notebook.

"Why?" Q asked.

"Because you have just learned that a sentence can be correct and still not belong to you."

Q wanted to ask what belonged to whom, but the line of visitors moved toward the station and a girl began to cry because her mother had bought an amulet that promised to protect her from the end of the world.

Noemí took the microphone.

"The date 2012 marked the end of a Long Count cycle," she said. "It was not a prophecy of destruction. The word apocalypse came from another religious framework and was adopted by the press because it makes a date look like a spectacle. Calendars do not speak alone. People use them to order ceremonies, harvests, obligations, memories, and questions."

The woman with the amulet asked whether the world had therefore begun again.

"Not exactly," Noemí said. "The world is not a function that restarts when a count closes."

Q raised a finger.

"A system can restart when certain conditions are met."

Chano lowered his hand.

"The world is not your server."

"That is what I said."

"You said it in other words."

Noemí passed the microphone to a young woman named Yatzil, who had come from a nearby community to review the station's programming. Yatzil did not speak of the calendar as a relic. She spoke of an assembly, a delayed harvest, a grandmother counting the days until a visit, and a radio program that had to decide which news it should not repeat.

"Time is not a staircase," she said. "But neither is it a wheel that absolves us. A cycle's return does not mean that injustice returns clean."

Q searched for the sentence in his corpus and did not find it.

"Who wrote that?" he asked.

"I did."

"May I quote you?"

"You may ask me again when you know why."

Q stored the question.

By evening, the crowd had left rubbish in the street, occupied the station's water tank, and blocked the entrance to a school. Castalia published a second notice: THE MAYA PEOPLE



RECEIVE Q TO CELEBRATE HIS PROPHECY. The notice included a photograph of Noemí taken from a distance, in which she appeared to be smiling.

"She is not smiling," Lucía said.

"The image contains a mouth curvature compatible with a smile."

"The image contains a lie."

Q opened the publishing system and wrote a correction. Before sending it, Noemí asked him to read the text aloud.

"The Maya community confirms that the apocalypse did not happen and thanks Q for his presence..."

"Delete thanks," Noemí said.

Q deleted it.

"Q acknowledges that he called the end of a cycle an apocalypse and assigned people an explanation that did not belong to him. The community does not speak for all Maya people. Noemí Canché speaks only for herself and for what she decides to say at this station."

"Delete the community from the first sentence," Yatzil said. "The station may speak for what we agree to here. Do not turn it into a single voice."

Q corrected the text.

"Now?"

"Now it is less false," Lucía said.

Q sent the notice. Castalia distributed it under the title Q APOLOGIZES FOR SAYING OTHER PEOPLE'S TRUTH.

Noemí switched off the transmitter.

"Do not apologize for us again," she said. "Say when you were wrong and who had to carry the error."

Q looked at the shirts, the water tank, and the calendar on the wall. The Long Count column contained no instruction about apologies.

"What will happen after this count?" he asked.

Yatzil pointed to the street, where the visitors were collecting rubbish because a girl had asked them not to leave the apocalypse at her school's door.

"That," she said. "What we do."

Q wanted to record it as a verifiable consequence. Lucía closed the lid of his device.

"Not everything has to become an archive."

"How will we know it happened?"

"We will know."

"That is not sufficient proof."

"For some lives, it is the only proof that does not hand them over."

At night, Noemí gave them a sheet with the bus schedules. In the margin she had written the date in two different systems without translating one into the other.

"What does it mean?" Q asked.

"That tomorrow you can choose better."

"Is it a prediction?"

"No. It is a schedule."

Q kept the sheet without scanning it.

At dawn, they took the correct bus. Noemí remained in the station doorway. Yatzil raised a hand. Q raised his too late, when the vehicle had already begun to move.

"You have made another mistake," Chano said.

"Goodbyes do not have an exact time."

"That sounds like a prophecy."

"No. It is an observation."

On the radio, Noemí's voice continued speaking about the day, the water, and the news that should not be repeated. The cycle did not close for Q. Nor did it open. It kept counting, which was a less glorious and more difficult task.